O.P. JINDAL GLOBAL

Institution of Eminence Deemed to be

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BUSINESS COMMUNICATION

End-term Exam Assignment

1. Listening as Both Art and a Science

Listening is an art and a science, as well, as it requires emotional intelligence and technical proficiency. Listening, as an art, demands empathy, patience and presence. It means listening to not only words, but tone, pauses and body language (Farber & Palm, 2025). For example, a colleague of mine based in India was presenting a data issue during a team meeting at UPS. His words were correct, but I heard the pause and anxiety in his voice. I used empathy and open-ended questions to coax him to share some concerns he was withholding. This underscores the fact that listening is about, among other things, understanding emotional information, which is such an important aesthetic aspect.

From a scientific perspective the other side as well: listening is also a cognitive activity. It requires focused attention and direct feedback. In cross-cultural environments, developing active listening is crucial for reduction of misunderstanding, particularly in a global corporation such as UPS. According to Brownell (2012) listening involves sensing (hearing the message), interpretating (understanding meaning), and evaluating (judging its accuracy) – all very much scientific acts if one subscribes to cognitive science.

For instance, I was once asked to observe culture's influence on how different members of our UK and US teams communicate during a data review call. Americans were more to the point, whereas my European colleagues liked a little nuance. Scientific listening enabled me to respond to these cues without reading them as intent. It is also known that active listening improves team performance by facilitating collaboration and decreasing conflict (Weger et al., 2014). This is especially true in multicultural teams, where accents, idioms, and expectations vary.

At its essence, listening is both an art in terms of establishing relationships, and a science in terms of understanding. The juxtaposition of these two distinct but interrelated sets of skills allow you to build trust and accuracy and convey respect especially in diverse, professional settings.

2. Understanding Nonverbal Communication in Intercultural Contexts

When I shared with a friend that I was studying how cultures use their nonverbal communication similarly and differently, she found it contradictory. I clarified that the "similarly and differently" concept means that many cultures share similar elements of nonverbal communication with similar categories; gestures, facial expressions, and body posture, yet the meanings and interpretations can be drastically different.

A simple example is the nodding motion; in most of the West it is a sign of agreement, whereas in some South Asian cultures it can signify; in some situations, uncertainty or even disagreement, as the same motion can hold a range of meanings (Cain & Gay, 2012).

In my role at UPS Sweden, we have weekly team meetings which include team members from the US, UK, India, and Germany. I have noticed, for example, American colleagues are very expressive in their gesture use, while their facial expressions are more obvious as well. Some of the Asian colleagues, Japanese and Chinese in particular, displayed a much less expressive style of communication. Unless one understands that these differences exist in nonverbal norms, the opportunity for misunderstanding is expansive.

According to Matsumoto and Hwang (2013), cultures have some commonality, in that all cultures communicate nonverbally through facial expressions, gestures, and eye contact; however, cultures will vary in how they use those forms of nonverbal communication, what they mean or represent, and when they are used. Just one example; in the West, eye contact can show confidence; while in some areas, such as some East Asian cultures, it could show disrespect.

An example that particularly struck me was when I was discussing performance feedback with a team member from South Korea. I was attempting to maintain direct eye contact and demonstrate that I was engaged in the conversation, but I sensed that he was uncomfortable. I later reflected that my use of eye contact and engagement may have been perceived as excessively assertive and involved cultural elements that I had not given thought to. This situation reminded me that I can be in touch with my own culturally driven instincts, while being mindful of the nonverbal customs of others.

Such insights serve to smooth intracultural relations, reduce conflict, and promote mutual respect. It also keeps us from misinterpreting intent or feeling just because someone communicates in a way that we do not.

3. Observing Gendered Communication: Mansplaining and Gaslighting

We also have at UPS Sweden certain instances of gendered communication, in form of mansplaining and gaslighting, that are subtle, but impactful. While we were having our cross-functional analytics meeting, a male employee insisted on explaining a very simple time series forecasting model to a female team lead multiple times even though she was the one who created it. She had explained the model's reasoning clearly, but he persisted in restating it, even correcting her needlessly. It's an example of what we would call mansplaining, where a man is explaining things to a woman in a super condescending way, presuming that she doesn't know something.

A different example related to gaslighting. At a planning meeting, a junior female colleague expressed concerns about deadlines that were impossible to meet. A senior manager responded by essentially asking her if she remembered any of the previous conversations and hinting that she was overreacting. And in the next few weeks, she began to wonder about her own decision making. Several team members later confirmed her fears about the timeline had been well founded. As Gergen (2015) notes, 'gaslighting' is the doing of something that causes the victim to doubt themselves and their reality; something that is often done to de-stabilize women in their professional lives.

These stories show how gendered communication can skew the workplace. It influences both morale and teamwork effectiveness. Conscious interventions with the organization, like training for awareness or inclusive pattern of communication could be necessary to correct these patterns.

4. Cultural Variations and Global Workplaces

Some variations naturally exist in cultures like the styles of communication, values, time orientation, and power distance. At UPS Sweden, I collaborate with individuals from the US, the UK, the EU nations and Asia. I know how these differences pervade everything from meeting dynamics to decision making. American colleagues, for instance, are known for being direct and task-oriented; European counterparts often see the merit in consensus and diplomacy. Asian team members tend to value respect, hierarchy and group harmony.

These differences can be better understood with the help of Hofstede's cultural dimensions. By contrast, the U.S. scores high in individualism, meaning individuals value personal accomplishment. Many Asian societies, however, tend to score high on collectivism, where the teams and the group goals are more important than the individual's (Hofstede, 2011). These differences affect how people provide feedback, how they handle conflict and how they participate in meetings.

There are pros and cons to working in a culturally rich space. It promotes creativity, innovation, and international mindedness. Yet it also creates confusion, particularly around communication and expectations. For example, when a cross-regional data project was held up, it was because certain team members were waiting for updates from others, while the others were waiting for the group to conclude. This disconnects slowed communication and created pressure.

There are two key strategies that tend to work quite well for managing collaboration on a global scale:

1. **Establish Common Norms**: Setting expectations around how to communicate, deadlines, and ways to give and receive feedback can aid in avoiding miscommunication. For instance, our team utilized a shared online document to keep track of feedback and deadlines for information, which smoothed the transition of direct the indirect communications between the teams.
2. **Cultural Sensitivity Training:** Training staff about cultural idioms fosters empathy and minimizes bias. Research on intercultural training demonstrates that it increases team cohesion and lowers friction (Gudykunst, 2004).

Through better communication and embracing of cultural differences, diverse teams can operate more effectively and deliver better results.

5. A Difficult Professional Conversation

A difficult conversation I once had was with a senior colleague at UPS Sweden regarding a misunderstood data dashboard. My dashboard was called out in a client call for not showing current metrics. I was called out and blamed by my fellow-employee in front of entire team, even though the problem was not in the dashboard logic, it was a delay in backend updates.

Immediately after the call, I was frustrated and cornered. I asked for a one-on-one to clear the air. When we met I explained in all calmness the technical side and the logs that showed that the delay was only on the server side. Instead of placing blame, I focused on facts and how we could avoid situations like this. My friend became defensive at first, but in time saw my point.

Stone, Patton, & Heen (2010) say that success in challenging discussion relies on the ability to separate intent from impact and to balance assertion and empathy. I attempted to do this, by rising above the criticism but explaining how the public criticism affected me, meanwhile as I could see the pressure he might have felt in front of the client, I let it go at that moment. This changed the attitude from confrontation to being inclusive and positive for collaboration.

The communication worked as the fix for the problem. But it did put a strain on our relationship for the time being. For a couple of weeks, there was awkwardness and less collaboration. As we collaborated on new projects over the years, mutual respect was gradually restored.

What I learned from this incident is that both transparency and professionalism, coupled with emotional intelligence are essential in very high-stress conversations. It also solidified for

me the importance of speaking out respectfully when your work and your integrity are at play.

Thinking about my mistake has made me a better communicator and team player.

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